Public Bid Opportunity Scanning — Build-Your-Own Kit

A process doc + LLM screening prompt for finding solar/storage/microgrid/EV public bid work on SAM.gov and state/local portals

SHARED WITH AMICUS O&M COOPERATIVE · JEFF CANTIN, SOLAR ALTERNATIVES · SEPTEMBER 2026

> This is the process our own scan runs on internally, generalized so any member can stand up their own version. No central dashboard — each company's territory, licensing, and risk tolerance are different enough that a one-size system would fight everyone's edge cases. Two pieces: (1) this process doc, (2) a paste-in LLM prompt with placeholders for your own criteria.

1. Data sources

Federal — SAM.gov

Free, public, nationwide. Federal work generally needs no state contractor license — the only real question is practicality (mobilization cost, lead time, scope fit). This is the highest-signal, lowest-cost source to automate.

State / local — subscription portals

MyBidMatch, BidNet Direct, and individual state procurement sites (e.g. your state's DAS/DOA bid board) are subscription- and state-specific. There is no single free API across states. Sign up for the portals covering your licensed states; most offer an email digest or RSS you can still run through the same screening logic below.

2. SAM.gov API setup

1. Get a free API key at `sam.gov` → account settings → "Request Public API Key." Approval is usually instant.
2. Search endpoint (opportunities):

```
GET https://api.sam.gov/prod/opportunities/v2/search
  ?postedFrom=MM/dd/yyyy&postedTo=MM/dd/yyyy
  &ncode=237130&keyword=solar
  &limit=100&offset=0&api_key=YOUR_KEY
```

`postedFrom` / `postedTo` are required and the range can't exceed 1 year. Run daily or 2–3x/week with a rolling few-day window to avoid missing anything.

3. Description endpoint (full text, not included in search results):

```
GET https://api.sam.gov/prod/opportunities/v1/noticedesc?noticeid={id}
&api_key=YOUR_KEY
```

4. Attachments: each opportunity has a `resourceLinks` array of direct download URLs — append `?api_key=YOUR_KEY` to fetch. PDFs and DOCX are usually parseable as text; scanned/handwritten attachments (e.g. site-visit sign-in sheets) need OCR or a rendered image review.
5. Rate limit is generous for a non-federal account (roughly 1,000 requests/day) — plenty for a scheduled scan.

3. NAICS & keyword recipe

NAICS	Description	Note
237130	Power & Communication Line and Related Structures Construction	Core code for microgrid/utility-scale install work — often hides real scope behind a vague title.
238210	Electrical Contractors	Broad; expect noise, worth including for smaller commercial jobs.
221114	Solar Electric Power Generation	Catches both real generation-facility work AND non-install noise (REC trading, equipment purchases) — see false positives below.
238220	Plumbing/HVAC/electrical-adjacent	Occasionally used for combined mechanical/electrical scopes with a solar/battery component.

Keywords: solar, photovoltaic, PV, battery energy storage, BESS, microgrid, EV charging, electric vehicle charging station, backup power, renewable energy, hybrid power, grid-tied, net metering, distributed generation.

> **Also manually eyeball non-flagged titles** containing "hybrid," "renewable," "microgrid," "battery," or "backup power" even without the word "solar" — keyword filters miss real scope hiding behind titles like "Guard Station Hybrid Electrical Improvements." Worth a quick title scan of the full batch, not just the flagged subset.

4. False-positive patterns (the expensive lessons)

- **RECs / certificate trading** (still NAICS 221114) — not install work.

- **Solar-*powered* equipment purchases** — radar trailers, ATC systems, solar generators, solar-powered barrier/wedge systems, individual panel SKUs. These are product buys (often NAICS 3xxxxx or 532490), not construction.
- **International embassy/consulate equipment RFQs** (e.g. "Solar Equipment" purchases via INL/State) — locally-managed product purchase, no install scope, even for named consumer products (Tesla Powerwall etc.).
- **Repair materials genuinely self-performed by government staff** — a "solar field repair" can be a parts buy with government staff doing the labor. Check attachments for a self-perform clause. (If a crew is actually being dispatched, see Partial Fit below instead of screening it out.)
- **UPS / facility battery backup** ≠ solar/ESS — "battery install" language can be pure IT/facility UPS work with zero PV component.
- **"Solar system" as astronomy** — NASA/Grants.gov "Solar System Exploration" is literal planets.
- **Stale/republished notices** — always check the deadline against today's date; a relevance flag doesn't mean the window is still open.
- **Duplicates** — the same listing often appears across multiple purchasing groups or portals. Cross-check titles before treating each hit as a separate lead.
- **Generic "backup power system"** without solar/battery/renewable language is usually generator/ATS/diesel work.

> **Note on maintenance and de-solarizing work:** earlier versions of this list treated all maintenance-only and de-solarizing listings as noise. That's too blunt — see Partial Fit below before screening these out.

5. Partial fits — maintenance and de-solarizing work worth surfacing

Not every real opportunity is a new install. Maintenance contracts and de-solarizing (removal) work are worth flagging as a **Partial Fit** — a step below Solid Fit — whenever the scope requires dispatching an experienced field team and could put an Amicus member's O&M/service capability to work, even if your own company doesn't chase that kind of contract directly.

- **PV systems maintenance / service contracts** — recurring inspection, cleaning, troubleshooting, module replacement, inverter service. Real skilled work, often a good fit for a dedicated O&M shop even when it's not new construction.
- **De-solarizing (array removal)** — panel/array removal ahead of a re-roof, a site repurposing, or decommissioning. Requires the same rigging, electrical disconnect, and safety skill as an install, just in reverse. Worth a look, especially if reinstallation is part of the same scope.

Keep these as Noise when the listing is purely administrative maintenance self-performed by government/facility staff, or the scope is too small/one-off to justify mobilizing a crew at all.

6. Enrichment — do this for anything that survives screening

1. **Place of performance** — the feed's location field is often the contracting office, not the job site. Pull the description and any attachments and look for "located," "Project Work Site," or an address block to confirm the actual site.
2. **Site visit** — check for a mandatory site visit date and RSVP/registration deadline. A missed mandatory visit raises the bar but isn't automatically disqualifying — some agencies will still accept a bid or let you request an exception.
3. **Set-asides** — note any DBE/8(a)/HUBZone/SDVOSB restriction. If you don't qualify, these are still worth flagging as a sub-to-prime opportunity.
4. **Sign-in sheets** — some agencies post the site-visit attendee roster as an attachment. If it's a scanned/handwritten PDF, render it as an image and read visually — text extraction usually returns nothing. This tells you who else is bidding.
5. **Lead time** — state days-until-deadline explicitly for every item you route to a person. A great scope match with a 4-day window is not actionable.

7. Bucketing & routing

Every item should land in one of four buckets before it reaches a human:

Bucket	Definition
Solid fit	Real new install/construction scope, live deadline, you're eligible (license/geography/set-aside).
Partial fit	Maintenance or de-solarizing work that needs an experienced field team dispatched — not new construction, but real skilled work (section 5). Especially worth sharing with cooperative members who run dedicated O&M/service operations.
Marginal / awareness	Matches technically but wrong scope, unlicensed territory, or a dead/tight deadline. Still worth sharing — especially to a peer network for a hand-off.
Noise	Keyword false positive per section 4.

Route solid fits into whatever your team already uses for pipeline (CRM, spreadsheet, Slack channel) with a deadline flag. Route partial fits and marginal items to peers whose focus or territory fits better rather than dropping them — that's exactly the value of a cooperative.

8. Cadence

Twice a week is enough for SAM.gov given the required posting-date window and typical 30–60 day response windows. Run more often only if you're chasing short-fuse Sources Sought notices. State/local portals are worth checking on their own schedule since volume and format vary a lot by state.

Questions or want to compare notes on your own version of this? Reach out to Jeff Cantin, Solar Alternatives. No strings attached — if a lead from your scan is out of your territory, we're glad to take a look too.